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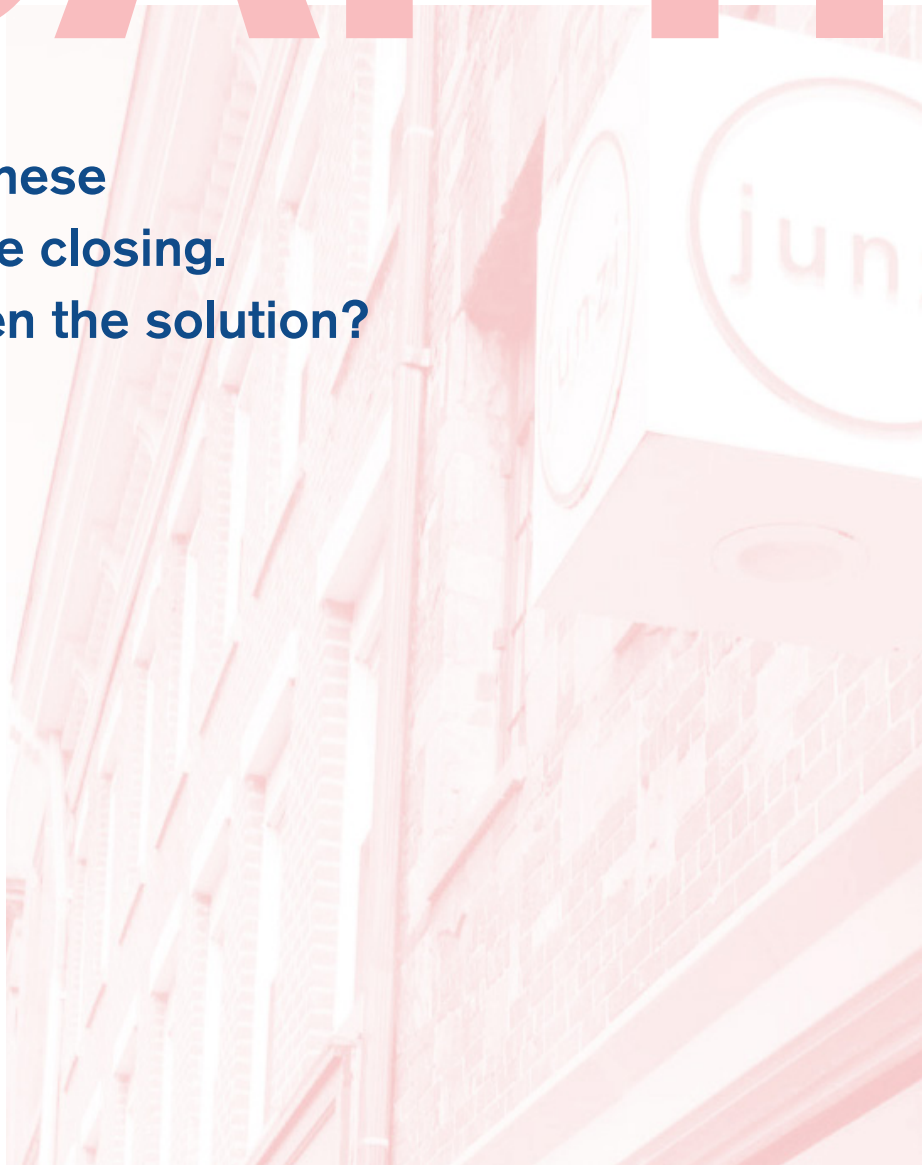
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ADAPTI

America's Chinese restaurants are closing. Is Junzi Kitchen the solution?



CUISINE

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BY **EMILY TIAN**

CHINESE RESTAURANTS in America have long led a double life. The strip mall joints my family and I frequented in our suburban enclave of Washington, D.C. could serve up a mean plate of salted duck or spicy beef intestines for its regulars just as well as any order from the Americanized side of the menu. The pan paid no favorites to what it cooked. When the wok was on, it was *on*, and takeout box after takeout box of lo mein or sweet and sour chicken would be delivered, steaming hot, to the counter.

When I came home for Thanksgiving break last semester, my family and I drove to one of our favorite restaurants. Run by a family from Sichuan, it was mostly patronized by local Chinese families. Yelp reviewers often docked stars for its ambience. It was true the place was not much by way of appearance: the shingled corner seemed held together year-round by blinking strings of Christmas lights. Weekly specials, listed on a white-



board in Chinese, were a shibboleth for nonfluent clientele. Couples stared almost fearfully at the mountain of peppers atop a volcanic fish stew, while others, in larger parties, ladled dishes from spinning glass platters.

This time, however, we pulled up to a paper flyer taped hastily on its door, thanking customers for their business and announcing its abrupt closure. Its owners had been cooking and running the restaurant for years, and they had decided it was time to retire.

Closures like this one have been mirrored thousandfold across the country. According to *The New York Times*, around 1,200 Chinese restaurants in the top 20 metropolitan areas have closed in the past five years, though restaurant numbers at large have been marching upward.

But the team at Junzi Kitchen—an upstart Chinese fast-casual chain—thinks they can break this pattern. Born out of the Yale Entrepreneurial Institute five years ago, the company is ambitious, youthful, and catching the eye of the industry's au courant.

At Junzi Kitchen, there are no paper zodiac placemats, no General Tso's chicken, and frequently, no Chinese cooks. Located on Broadway in New Haven, Junzi Kitchen's design is spare and unfussy, and its whitewashed interior could easily have been lifted out of a Scandinavian architecture catalog. To the skepticism of some purists, it has managed to squeeze a cuisine of shared dishes and intensive preparation methods into single-serving bowls cooked up by an assembly line.

Can bringing Sweetgreen to stir fry help save an embattled industry?

YONG ZHAO FES '08 GRD '15, Wanting Zhang FES '11, and Ming Bai ART '13 first laid out a business outline for Junzi in a proposal for a Yale Entrepreneurial Institute accelerator program. As Chinese graduate students at Yale, they had heard of Lucas Sin '15, an enterprising young chef preparing pop-up dinners in his dorm room, who has since been the restaurant's vital culinary talent. Since its brick-and-mortar opening in 2015, the chain has quickly expanded to include three other storefronts in New York City.

Junzi prides itself on a vegetable-centered menu drawing not only from traditional Chinese cooking but also catering to a health-conscious audience. Its signature bing is the wheat-based Chinese equivalent of a burrito, but it is thinner and stretchier, swaddling sliced vegetables like bean sprouts and daikon.

A bowl of noodles, doused in tomato and egg sauce, is another popular chef recommendation. An after-hours menu available on weekend late nights turns out glazed custard buns, scallion pancakes, and other indulgent snack foods, while a monthly ticket-based "Chef's Study" with Sin sets the table for more creative fine dining.

Junzi's glass-paneled open kitchen reduces the mysticism of cooking and restauranteering and follows a distinctively fast-casual deference to customer choice. The build-your-own option, priced at ten dollars, breaks dinner down into familiar categories for a contemporary gourmand: base, protein, and assorted vegetables. Junzi borrows from the playbook of Sweetgreen, Chipotle, and a farrago of other health-forward, fast-casual chains while preserving staples of northern Chinese fare.

Junzi's culinary revolution doesn't end with its menu. Loyal customers can opt into its rewards program, enroll in a monthly dining plan, or purchase Junzi-stylized tote bags and pop sockets. It constructs similar brand consciousness through

its online and social media presence. It made immediate partnerships with third-party delivery apps like Grubhub and Seamless and jumped quickly at the opportunity to work with the ghost kitchen service Zuul Kitchens—a delivery-exclusive kitchen shared by different restaurants—in its fifth outpost in downtown New York.

"From the beginning, we said that we weren't opening just for one [location]," Zhao said in an interview with *The Politic*. "Some small fishes are always small fishes. Others become whales. This entire business has to be scalable."

A quick Google search for Chinese restaurants in New York City yields descriptions like "no-frills," "low-key," "laid-back," and "small and humble": even such terms of endearment insinuate their undistinguished place in the culinary industry's pecking order. In mission, operations, and design, Junzi bears little resemblance to the antecedent wave of Chinese restaurants, owned largely by first-generation immigrants with few other available career paths. But Junzi's mission extends beyond itself: the team believes that their model can help reinvent how Chinese cuisine is consumed, served, and conceived of in America.

Last November, Junzi Kitchen accrued $5 million from investors in a preliminary funding round as part of an ambitious plan to buy Chinese takeout restaurants on the brink of closure and remodel them under the Junzi umbrella. Early investments poured in from venture capitalist groups like DOM Capital, LDY Ventures, and Uniwill Ventures, as well as Union Square Hospital Group CEO Chip Wade, who has worked with popular chains like Olive Garden. This plan is still in the works, but the Junzi team hopes to introduce new employee training, hiring practices, and kitchen technology.

"A lot of Chinese restaurants don't have the budget to design the brand and want to sell their business," explained Zhao. These are the restaurants Junzi hopes to purchase and renovate. "A lot of Chinese restaurants need an overdue facelift. We want to provide a new Chinese takeout model in America for the local community with greater trust and new operations as well as local staff. The menu items will be similar but with improvements: healthier options for new generations."

Junzi's success has also inspired rising business owners like Sarah Mandelbaum SOM '19. In 2018, Mandelbaum created a plant-based dumpling brand called Brazen Eats with the support of Yale's entrepreneurial ecosystem.

"The Junzi team came to speak over lunch one day. My biggest takeaway was they had a very clear mission to build better understandings between cultures, with a high-level story and a strong target segment," she said in an interview with *The Politic*. "You feel so connected, like, if you eat at Junzi you make the world a better place."

This strategy—what CEO and co-founder Yong Zhao likes to call the "Chinesification of American restaurants"—looks like it's working.

THE OBSTACLES AHEAD of the Junzi team, however, are numerous. First is the massive footprint of existing Chinese restaurants. There are upwards of 40,000 of these establishments in America: surpassing the number of McDonald's, KFC, and Burger King franchises combined, as Jennifer 8. Lee points out in her book *The Fortune Cookie Chronicles*. They dot highways in the Midwest, bump shoulder-to-shoulder in the Bay area, and are near-ubiquitous fixtures to suburban shopping plazas. And then there's the history: these menus are a striking fossil record of changing tastes and perceptions.

Chinese cooking arrived in the United States alongside the first stream of immigrant laborers from southern China in the early 1800s, but large-scale consumption of Chinese cuisine was beleaguered by persistent anti-Chinese sentiment. Around the turn of the 20th century, chop suey—a curious marriage of Cantonese cooking methods and American flavors—soon heralded a new age of American-Chinese cuisine. While the fusion dishes soon won over the public, decades of restricted immigration, bracketed by the the Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882 and the Immigration and Nationality Act of 1965, increasingly detached American-Chinese cooking from mainland cuisine.

With the relaxation of immigration policy in the 1960s, however, new waves of Chinese immigrants in the country brought more regional, traditional flavors. Many, with limited access to other professional opportunities, turned to the labor-intensive restaurant industry out of necessity. Now, as these immigrants push on the age of retirement, their children have fewer incentives to continue the business. *The New York Times* reports that self-employed second-generation Chinese immigrants are far more likely to work in industries like tech, dentistry, or consulting rather than in food or construction.

"There's sort of a crisis in the family-owned restaurant as the children go to medical school or the parents aren't that interested in the kids continuing a business that's hard and non-professional," said Paul Freedman, the Chester D. Tripp Professor of History at Yale, in an interview with *The Politic*. Freedman's recently published book, *Ten Restaurants that Changed America*, features Cecilia Chiang's famed San Francisco establishment, The Mandarin, which helped introduce Americans to regional Chinese cuisine.

The impact of these small businesses reach beyond the families who own them: restaurant work often involves grueling conditions and long hours. "We need to think about how those Chinese owners are complicit in contributing to the exploitation of labor," said Annie Cheng '20 in an interview with *The Politic*, pointing out that Chinese restaurants have long been under fire for underpaying and overworking their employees, including vulnerable undocumented workers. Cheng spent last summer as a culinary apprentice with the Junzi team, playing a role in recipe development, and herself plans to build a career in the restaurant industry.

Be it the waning of an era or a phenomenon of upward mobility, the erosion of these family-owned restaurants—along with the increase of Chinese-born students and working professionals in the United States—is opening up opportunities for a youth-

ful contingent of restaurateurs like Zhao and his colleagues.

Junzi, of course, is far from the only representative of this new generation of Chinese restaurants. Asian food halls are exploding. Some popular mainland chains are venturing into the states. In recent years, New York's hip East Village has become a veritable Chinatown of its own. But Junzi's assembly line production system and restaurant renewal initiative affirm an unwavering commitment to its own model.

"I HAD A LOT OF OPINIONS about my mom's food—constructive ones. But I soon took matters into my own hands," said student chef Andy Zhao '23 in an interview with *The Politic*. He landed his first job taking shifts at a smoothie bar and spent his junior year of high school behind an open counter at a Japanese restaurant. At Yale, he

"SOMETIMES YOU MIX NOST

spends Fridays in the Silliman buttery as part of the cook team for Y Pop-Up, the Yale student-run pop-up restaurant concept, which Sin first launched as an undergraduate.

When Andy's family visited him at college, he took them to Junzi. His parents took one long look at the restaurant and decided to leave. "They saw the fact that the people working behind the counter weren't Asian and saw it as not authentic," explained Andy.

Still, "while it's not exactly authentic, it's not sticky and sweet. I don't see why Junzi can't do the same as [Chipotle]," said Andy. "Its dishes are forward-thinking but not unusual. Customers want a recognizably distinct Asian food but they don't want to be scared by it."

Junzi's investment in aged Chinese takeout restaurants not only presents opportunities to revitalize local businesses, but also a chance for Junzi to broaden the palates of those who have previously only dined at Americanized Chinese restaurants

like Panda Express and P.F. Chang's.

Chinese-born immigrants like Andy's parents may be dubious about the pragmatism that Junzi embraces. But Junzi's goal isn't to replicate tradition for tradition's sake. Although their flavors are familiar to Chinese customers, they are also purposefully accessible to those with less experience with Chinese cuisine.

Despite Andy's mother's qualms, teaching Chinese culinary methods to local non-Chinese employees is essential to Junzi's mission.

"The goal is to make Chinese food really accessible to everyone, not just eaters but makers," said Cheng. "Anyone can understand Chinese food and Chinese flavors, and it is actually an avenue to understand Chinese culture."

"We're rewriting a new textbook for beginner markets," Yong Zhao said.

By contrast, one of the most prominent chainlets in the Chinese fast-casual industry—Xi'An Famous Foods in New York—is operating under a radically different restaurant model. When it opened in 2005, customers huddled in a Flushing basement stall to purchase a bowl of noodles festooned in spiced cumin lamb and chili oil. Intrepid crowds found the hole-in-a-wall appeal as another springboard for its authenticity.

Fifteen years later, Xi'An Famous Foods is still a family-owned institution, albeit a popular one. Its website firmly reprimands visitors, "No, we do not franchise." It does not deliver nor take orders by phone: the owners are quick to acknowledge that the noodle dishes don't do well after being left out for an extended time. Forgoing Junzi's innovative campaigns for a loyal customer base with urbane tastes, however, may make Xi'An good business for cosmopolitan New York, but less popular in other regions of America.

JUNZI'S INNOVATIONS in the fast-casual market may also herald one of the most elusive dreams of Chinese chefs: representation of Chinese cuisine in fine-dining.

Professor Freedman offers that the absence of Chinese fine-dining restaurants, compared to other international cuisines like French and Japanese, is related to the "endearing image of the country and the people immigrating from it." Other scholars and economists have similarly suggested that prevailing ethnic stereotypes have stunted the growth of Chinese restaurants beyond the takeout model.

TALGIA WITH AUTHENTICITY."

One less political obstacle is that high-end restaurants tend to lend themselves to small group dining, whereas traditional Chinese dining is festive, and for some, ostentatious. "In Chinese restaurants somebody is always entertaining. You all partake in the same possibilities," Freedman said. "[A high-end Chinese restaurant in America] would look probably like a Japanese restaurant. Modern, minimalist, Asian but in little touches."

But would the inclusion of Chinese restaurants in broader American dining entail a sacrifice of their authenticity?

Authenticity, however, is a slippery idea, and Yong Zhao is quick to offer a dose of reality. To survive and expand as a business, for Zhao, isn't just about taste but adaptability. He said, "[In China], you pay [with] WeChat and it's done. There are no fights over checks anymore. We don't see that as being authentic anymore. These are common memories, but you have to accept changes. Sometimes you mix nostalgia with authenticity."

In the coming months—the most significant litmus test for the restaurant industry in recent history—a forward-thinking business model and culinary imaginativity will not only be a competitive edge but a survival strategy. And while forced closures and high unemployment rates portend a shaky future for the industry, Junzi's healthy serving of pragmatism translates into community and cultural empowerment. They know as well as anyone that more than a bowl of noodles is at stake.

POLITICIZ

THE PAST

Can history be taught objectively?

BY **JULIA HORNSTEIN**

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PROFESSOR CHARLES HILL is not for want of histories. Hill, the Brady-Johnson Distinguished Fellow in Grand Strategy and an International Studies lecturer, is reading a book in his office at 31 Hillhouse Avenue, itself lined with volumes on every surface, when I walk in. He places his paperweight of choice, his father's axe head, in the open book's spine, gestures for me to take a seat, and waits for me to begin speaking.

Hill has taught at Yale since 1997. Before coming to Yale, he was a linchpin United States Foreign Service member and alternately a senior aide to George P. Shultz, Henry Kissinger, and Boutros Boutros-Ghali. He has seen generations of Yale students come through the Directed Studies program, an intensive humanity and philosophy track for first-years, and in Hill's mind, he teaches them nothing but the truth.

The telling of history in this country has been a contested subject since the birth of the American republic. In the early 20th century, William Archibald Dunning, historian of Reconstruction, noted the subjectivity of interpreting the past. In a 1914 essay in *The American Historical Review* entitled "Truth in History," Dunning asserted, "We must recognize frankly that whatever a given age or people believes to be true is true for that age and that people."

Historians' attempts to discover "truth" are situated in their own political moments, just as the histories they study are situated in theirs. But as partisanship has heightened in the past decades, these debates have become increasingly divided, especially on contentious subjects like race and identity in America.

In January 2020, an article in *The New York Times* reignited this dispute.

The piece by reporter Dana Goldstein tracked key differences in the same edition of textbooks distributed across the United States. Among the eight textbooks covered, Goldstein notes one particularly striking difference in a McGraw-Hill textbook. The California version notes relevant gun legislation on an annotated Bill of Rights; the Texas version ignores arms regulation, deleting the annotation completely while keeping the rest of the page intact.

Still, Goldstein's article acknowledges that this controversy extends beyond textbooks. The 2016 presidential election in particular marked a watershed moment in the way high school history courses are taught. Since then, the article posits, polarization and partisanship have occupied an increasingly noticeable presence in classrooms, as some teachers feel compelled to discuss their personal beliefs, opinions, and experiences. Beyond regional discrepancies, individual teachers and their various idiosyncrasies can determine how their students learn history.

Despite noticing a shift in the way students approach history—which Hill attributes to high school teachers increasingly imbuing their classes with their own perspectives—he believes it is possible to teach history free of external political influence. After all, he says, that's what he does.

WHEN JOSE GUERRERO '23 walked into his Advanced Placement (AP) United States History class his sophomore year at

Harris County High School in Hamilton, GA, he was surprised.

"I remember learning about states' rights in the Civil War [in middle school]," said Jose in an interview with *The Politic*. "From what I learned, I thought that Robert E. Lee was a good general and good person."

But in his class at Harris County High, the message was different.

His teacher, one of the few black faculty members at the school, pushed against the grain of his conservative hometown politics by placing an emphasis on alternative historical narratives, especially regarding African American history. "She really challenged us to look at different perspectives," Jose said.

But many of Jose's high school friends who weren't in his AP U.S. History class still believed the perspective they were taught. "The idea of states' rights was definitely emphasized in [their] classes," he remembered.

This disparity in the way American schools teach history is twofold. It reflects not only regional politics, but the kind of history education made possible in different kinds of schools, and even within schools.

Nine hundred and sixty-one miles north of Hamilton, at the Leon M. Goldstein High School for the Sciences in Brooklyn, NY, Shoshana Hershenstraus has no problem with teachers going beyond the assigned textbook. "I always inject the personal," Hershenstraus shared in an interview with *The Politic*.

As the daughter of Holocaust and World War II survivors, she cannot separate her past from her classroom in Manhattan Beach. She describes herself as a Baby Boomer—"a child of the sixties"—who frequented anti-war protests, women's rights demonstrations, and, most memorably, Woodstock. "My parents had no idea [I was there] until I found a phone booth and called them," Hershenstraus remembers. "Those are the kinds of things that affect you."

To Hershenstraus, adding her personal narrative is not only useful, but is the only way to get at historical truth. If she solely focused on what would most likely be tested on the AP exam in May, Hershenstraus would have omitted elements of America's past—particularly around activism and social justice—that she finds essential to the country's history. Sanitized historical narratives don't cut it.

Although some students "might have thought I spent too much time discussing race or xenophobia or the labor movement," she knew it was vital. "I really saw it as affecting me."

At the same time, Hershenstraus insists that bringing the personal into the classroom does not justify sacrificing accuracy or fact. Rather, she hopes her experiences enhance students' understanding of why history matters. "I really was very careful, I hope, to provide lots and lots of information and documents and have them sort of reach their own conclusion, and then have them debate," she said.

Plus, trying to conceal how her life affects her teaching would be disingenuous. "No matter what period you cover, [the students] feel like you lived it," she laughs. "I always tell them, 'You know, Abe Lincoln and I really weren't neighbors or anything, and I didn't even know FDR, for that matter.'"

AFTER TEACHING DIRECTED STUDIES classes for the past 23 years, Hill thinks his students are sometimes "giving you the words of their high school teacher."

Indeed, to Hill, the debate over the subjectivity of history is just a ploy for teachers to follow popular trends, to the detriment of their students' learning. In an interview with *The Politic*, Hill lamented that "America is a bad country" is now the prevailing historical narrative. By these newer methods, historians are expected "to tell the American story in a certain way and point out how every stage, every person, and every authority was bad."

It's just plain bias, he says.

In an interview with *The Politic*, Michael Franczak, a lecturer in History at Yale who teaches The United States in the Global 1970s: Politics, Economics, Society, said that he sees his role as "[making] students more conscious of the consequences and limitations of American power. That is not to say it can't be wielded for good."

Sanitized historical narratives don't cut it

Walking into the classroom, he, like Hill, is acutely aware of students' divergent pre-college curricula and preparation. "Students that didn't have the prep experience weren't on this track since they were kids," Franczak explains.

He points, for example, to a Texas law that mandates that all public schoolers take a course in Texas history. These courses often espouse textbook-endorsed views about the Second Amendment that you wouldn't find in the North. He wants students to question the truths they've been taught, and he doesn't purport to have the perfect account either.

Yale students themselves recognize that history is not a monolith. Alex Martin '23, for one, actively seeks this subjectivity when choosing classes. In Constitutional Law, which Martin took last fall, Professor Akhil Amar is known for teaching the Constitution from his own liberal originalist perspective. "I think it's great when professors put their perspective into class material," Martin said in an interview with *The Politic*. "It makes going to school intellectually exciting."

ALEX, A NATIVE OF ARKANSAS, was first introduced to the subjectivity of history at the Episcopal Collegiate School in Little Rock. Martin considers himself lucky: his teachers placed more emphasis on critical discussion than the intense memorization required for standardized test prep.

Inspired by his AP U.S. History teacher's passion for Little Rock's past, Martin independently researched the city's history of discriminatory housing policies, specifically redlining laws from the 1900s resulting from Jim Crow laws and sharecropping.

But Alex's friends at other schools in Arkansas did not receive the same support to pursue the research on tougher questions. History curricula were inconsistent, even within the same school district.

Shane "Chief" Martin, a high school history teacher at Mountain Brook High School in Birmingham, AL, finds that many AP courses create a false sense of security in absolute truth and an undeserved respect for memorization. As best he tries, it's impossible to be fully objective. There is an "obvious human bias we have toward our content," he said in an interview with *The Politic*.

Regardless of personal background, history is never so cut-and-dry. Martin is proud of his school's approach, which teaches students how to be critical thinkers and his-

torians, and treats facts as a jumping-off point for discussion and debate.

In nearby schools, though, students don't have the same experience. Martin described communities where "it's just get-the-content, just throw the facts at them and let's move on. It's kind of a churn-and-burn." Mountain Brook, on the other hand, "is about learning."

Alex remembers his own friends' frustrations about their "churn-and-burn" schools, particularly in the public school system. There is "a lack of emphasis on harder topics, like the atrocities Columbus committed and the brutality of U.S.-Native American interactions," Alex explained.

But things have been changing, at least in Mountain Brook. Martin shared, "It's not the traditional old views the way it used to be—it's a lot of change and a lot of it is because...we're willing to have discussions and have debates and ask tough questions."

HILL DESCRIBES HIS INTENTION as an educator as "teach[ing] everything as it [was] to the people who did it. I teach Marx as a serious Marxist. I don't teach it as a bad thing; I don't try to give a coloration to what I'm doing. I want to take it for what the people say it is."

"In other words," Hill clarified. "I want to tell the truth."

Despite increased national debate over history curricula, however, evidence suggests that today's college students are even less interested in historical inquiry than were generations prior. According to a 2019 *New Yorker* article, "The Decline of Historical Thinking," collegiate history department enrollments have been "declining more rapidly than any other major, even as more and more students attend college."

But although this is only his first semester lecturing at Yale, Franczak has already realized that history is taught differently here. "Yale is the only school in the country where history is the most popular major. It is such a unique place [for that]," Franczak said.

Alex finds that the strength of the history major lies in its malleability. "I think if we got to a place where professors thought that their perspectives weren't important—that their teaching must be dissociated from a perspective—it would be pretty bad," he said.

Alex worries that if professors hide their own views, "we'd have a situation where extremely talented, knowledgeable, well-researched professors would teach about something they're passionate about without giving the perspective as they understand it."

Franczak and Hill, although representative of two different teaching approaches, agree that Yale's emphasis on a nuanced understanding of history—and its shift away from the AP scantron bubble sheets many Yalies filled out in high school—is what makes its department so strong. This shift isolates Yale from both the rudimentary pedagogy of textbook learning and the regional politics that define the education of high schoolers across the country.

But does this goal always yield the truth? Is the truth even possible to achieve? Although, unlike Alex, most of Jose's high school history classes were taught by textbook, both students came to Yale to learn from the backgrounds of their professors and peers.

Perhaps most importantly, does it even matter? It is unclear if the benefit of the search for objectivity in history is actually in the ultimate goal itself, or whether it is derived from the process of truth-seeking.

"In my opinion," Martin argued, "if people are teaching from different perspectives, if those people can come together, I think it [ultimately] benefit[s] the kids because it generates such good discussion."

Hershenstraus agrees. Without bringing the personal into the classroom, history won't matter because students won't care. "Just having one paragraph on an event that has a big impact on future events doesn't do the kids justice, doesn't do the profession justice, and certainly doesn't do history justice."

Show of Support

Artists rally mutual aid in the wake of COVID-19

BY **SHIRA MINSK**

ON MARCH 11, Joshua Penman '01 texted his friend Aea, offering her money to cancel her album release concert scheduled for that night in Oakland, California. In the midst of the COVID-19 pandemic, he worried she would endanger both herself and her audience by choosing to perform.

She didn't respond.

But Penman, who studied music and mathematics at Yale and played full-time in a band after college, didn't give up there. He had realized that he could help mitigate the spread of the virus by paying performers for canceled shows.

That day, Penman started a GoFundMe page. "It was almost like a reflex—I just wanted to put something up and try to get people money to cancel their shows," he reflected in an interview with *The Politic*. A passionate composer, music producer, and software engineer, Penman recognized the precarious situation of many of his musician friends who were unable to afford the blow from a lost gig or performance.

"We're asking artists to take the financial hit for the good of the com-

munity," he said. "We're saying, 'Hey, nobody can go to your shows because social distancing measures are better for everybody, but you're going to lose that money.'"

Within only a few days, the dialogue surrounding COVID-19 had changed. Penman understood the crisis: "We've crossed from 'We might cancel our shows' to 'I just lost all of my work for the next two months,' and people are hurting unbelievably."

While COVID-19 has devastated the lives of many, artists and performers have been among the hardest hit. The pandemic has shocked an already-broken system of artist compensation, and artists have been left to pick up the pieces themselves. Congress has debated several responses to the pandemic, but few have addressed the needs of freelance workers. For freelance artists, paid time off does not exist, and employment protections—if any exist—vary drastically by state.

As hundreds of venues, from high-end theaters, orchestras, and ballets to smaller joints like clubs and weddings have postponed performances indefinitely, artists across the country have suffered. On March 12, Broadway suspended all performances until at least mid-April. A week later, the New York Metropolitan Opera—the largest performing arts organization in the United States—laid off all of its union employees, including its musicians and chorus.

"None of us have ever been wealthy," Mika Godbole, a New Jersey percussionist who teaches music at Rider University and Rowan University, explained to *The Politic*. "Every artist I know has been in that position of 'How am I going to pay rent this month?' Whether you're employed or not, whether you have gigs or not, we've all experienced that moment of extreme vulnerability."

WHEN FIONA WENCH graduated from Pennsylvania State University with a B.A. in acting in 2018, she moved to Manhattan with the hopes of becoming a theater or film actress. Although she has found some work in the industry since then, she has held a slew of part-time jobs—starting off as a nanny, then working in catering—to make ends meet.

The pandemic has shocked an already-broken system of artist compensation, and artists have been left to pick up the pieces themselves.

For the last six months, she has been working as a temp at a financial firm while attending auditions and acting classes when she can. In early March, her office closed for the foreseeable future. "I think I'm going to end up going back home to Maryland just to have some food in the fridge," Wench said in an interview with *The Politic*.

The pandemic will hit many artists' livelihoods twice over: their performances are postponed indefinitely and their second jobs are the next to be sacrificed. On April 2, the Department of Labor announced that 10 million people had filed for unemployment in the past two weeks.

"One of the things that is hardest for actors is that for a lot of us, our

survival jobs are hourly," Wench continued. "So when offices shut or people aren't hiring nannies because of social distancing, the source of income that we rely on when we're not in shows diminishes greatly."

For Wench's roommate, an actor and restaurant worker, these concerns are just as salient. "Every employee at that restaurant relies heavily on tips. You hope that if someone is sick, they won't come to work. But because everyone's income relies on showing up, it's a tricky situation," explained Wench.

For auditions, Wench and many of her friends are increasingly turning to self-tapes, which allow actors to send filmed material to casting directors. Wench expects that number will rise as the pandemic continues. Websites like SaveMyAudition.com, which usually charge actors for accompaniment that they can use in self-tapes, are offering free tracks to artists who can no longer attend live auditions due to the pandemic.

Still, while the industry is working to accommodate its auditioning actors, most productions have shut down or been postponed indefinitely due to the pandemic, making jobs that are hard to secure under normal circumstances even more difficult to find.

For Wench and her roommate, neither of whom are unionized, there is little guidance during this time. But even for actors covered by unions, things are complicated. Unions designed to support performers, like the Actors' Equity Association, the Screen Actors Guild, and the Stage Directors and Choreographers Society, are often unable to help.

Abigail Vega, an arts worker from San Antonio, TX shared that her colleagues were scared and confused, often with reason. "People were asking, 'What's my union doing for me?'" she recalled in an interview with *The Politic*. "If you are a union member and you have not heard from your union yet, that's a problem."

THE ART COMMUNITY can feel small. Godbole, the percussionist from New Jersey, was already thinking about how to help artists affected by the pandemic when she happened to come across Penman's GoFundMe. In early March, Godbole had been talking to friends over Facebook, trying to find solutions, and when the Metropolitan Opera announced that they were shutting their doors for the rest of the month on March 12, she realized she had to act fast. She scoured the internet for GoFundMe inspiration, which is where she found Penman.

That same day, Godbole opened her own fundraiser page targeted at helping performers in the tri-state area.

Even before Godbole had thought about starting a fundraiser, she had begun to lose gigs herself. As an adjunct professor, she considers herself lucky: most of her work has been moved online, and she knows that no matter what, she will still be paid. In late March, Godbole lost her job at the bookstore where she normally works during the day. "I've been furloughed, which isn't the worst thing in the world. I'm going to find a way to make it work somehow and keep fundraising," she maintained.

Soon after launching her own GoFundMe, Godbole joined with another relief fund run by Los Angeles-based organization Equal Sound, a non-profit that helps artists put together and fund their productions. Together, they are working to fundraise for artists impacted by COVID-19 all across the country.

"We are flying by the seat of our pants because we wanted to get this out as quickly as possible," said Godbole. "We're just figuring it out day-by-day." Soon, the joint fundraiser began to distribute funds on a rolling basis to any artist who could demonstrate income loss, either from official paperwork, emails from contractors, or just screenshots of texts from employers.

They allocated funds in proportion to demonstrated financial loss, with a cap of $500 per canceled gig.

Since Penman and Godbole started their relief funds in mid-March, dozens of similar fundraisers have been created on GoFundMe to support artists in different cities. One Seattle-based relief fund raised nearly $200,000 in only ten days. Facebook groups, too, have sprung up for artists in different fields to share opportunities and comfort amidst the chaos. In one group titled "NYC Covid-19 Musician Resources and Support," posts range from a musician asking for advice on how to tune her mother's old piano to another wondering how to file for unemployment.

Godbole offered one reason why support systems like these are so important: many freelancers do not have contracts for every gig. Performances are sometimes scheduled by email or word of mouth. Thus, venues can cancel on a moment's notice with no legal obligation to pay the performers, leaving artists financially stranded.

Godbole has seen drastic changes in her own life, too. With her regular university classes moved online, and without her gigs and regular time at the bookstore, she spends increasing hours stuck at home—and has focused much of her energy on the fundraiser.

By April 3, Godbole and Equal Sound had received 4,478 requests for funding and had made their first two rounds of payments to artists.

"Every artist I know has been in that position of 'How am I going to pay rent this month?' Whether you're employed or not, whether you have gigs or not, we've all experienced that moment of extreme vulnerability."

THE SAME DAY PENMAN texted Aea, actor, director, and educator Nicole Brewer asked the artEquity alumni Facebook group to collaborate on a comprehensive collection of resources for artists. ArtEquity, an anti-racist facilitation training program, was a natural fit for this initiative: the part-activist, part-artist members were excited to get to work. Brewer envisioned a webinar for artists to share resources, hear from community members and experts, and lean on each other.

Many artEquity alumni, including Vega, Anne Marie Lonsdale, and Hannah Fenlon, responded to Brewer's call. Quickly, Fenlon started populating a Google document with resources she had seen online. In the time it took her to enable the other alumni as administrators, the document had so much traffic that they could not properly access it. "I've never seen a Google Doc look like that," said Vega.

Soon, Fenlon transferred this information to a free WordPress site, "COVID-19 Freelance Artist Resources." The site, like the Google document, is a collaborative effort: anyone can submit resources through a Google Form. Within 48 hours, the page had over 200,000 unique views, a number that has since skyrocketed.

Within days of the site's founding, suggestions streamed in under

basic categories like Emergency Funding, Quantifying Economic Impact of Canceled Work, Best Practices for Online Teaching, and Advocacy Alerts. There are also sections providing for the long-term wellbeing of artists such as physical health, mental health, and interrupting racism and bias. The website links to other resource collections and upcoming virtual events.

On March 16, Brewer, Fenlon, Lonsdale, and Vega hosted a two hour-long webinar entitled "Artists In a Time of Global Pandemic," which featured guidance and comfort from lawyers, arts educators, financial advisors, and other community members. The webinar counted 4,456 unique views from all 50 states and 119 countries. "There's need all over the world, and what's really amazing is that we're actually reaching people," Lonsdale said to *The Politic*.

While these resources are essential for struggling artists, they do not remove the ever-present economic turmoil. "The theater industrial complex and the entertainment complex have ground to a halt," Brewer said. "Last week on Monday I got my first cancellation, Tuesday I got [another] cancellation, and I was beginning to panic."

Brewer was also scheduled to teach a workshop at the Yale School of Drama in late March. "We're currently in conversation about how to make that a digital convening instead of just flat-out canceling it," she said. Still, there are elements of working in person that cannot be carried over to the digital world.

"When we go to events, our work speaks for itself, but also networking is so critical to us getting future work. That's been shut down, and that kind of loss can't be quantified at this moment."

FIVE YEARS AGO, Penman decided to give up touring with his band to get a higher-paying job. The gigs had been coming slowly, and music didn't seem financially feasible in the long term.

But every three years, the software company where he now works gives its employees a sabbatical. His just so happened to begin in late March. He initially intended to use his composition training and his six weeks off to make an original album, but now, he plans to hire underemployed musicians to record themselves playing the different parts, and then overlay the tracks.

"I happen to be in a position to hire musicians right now, and there is certainly no shortage of them looking for work," he said. "It's great to fundraise money, but nothing can replace getting to make music with each other."

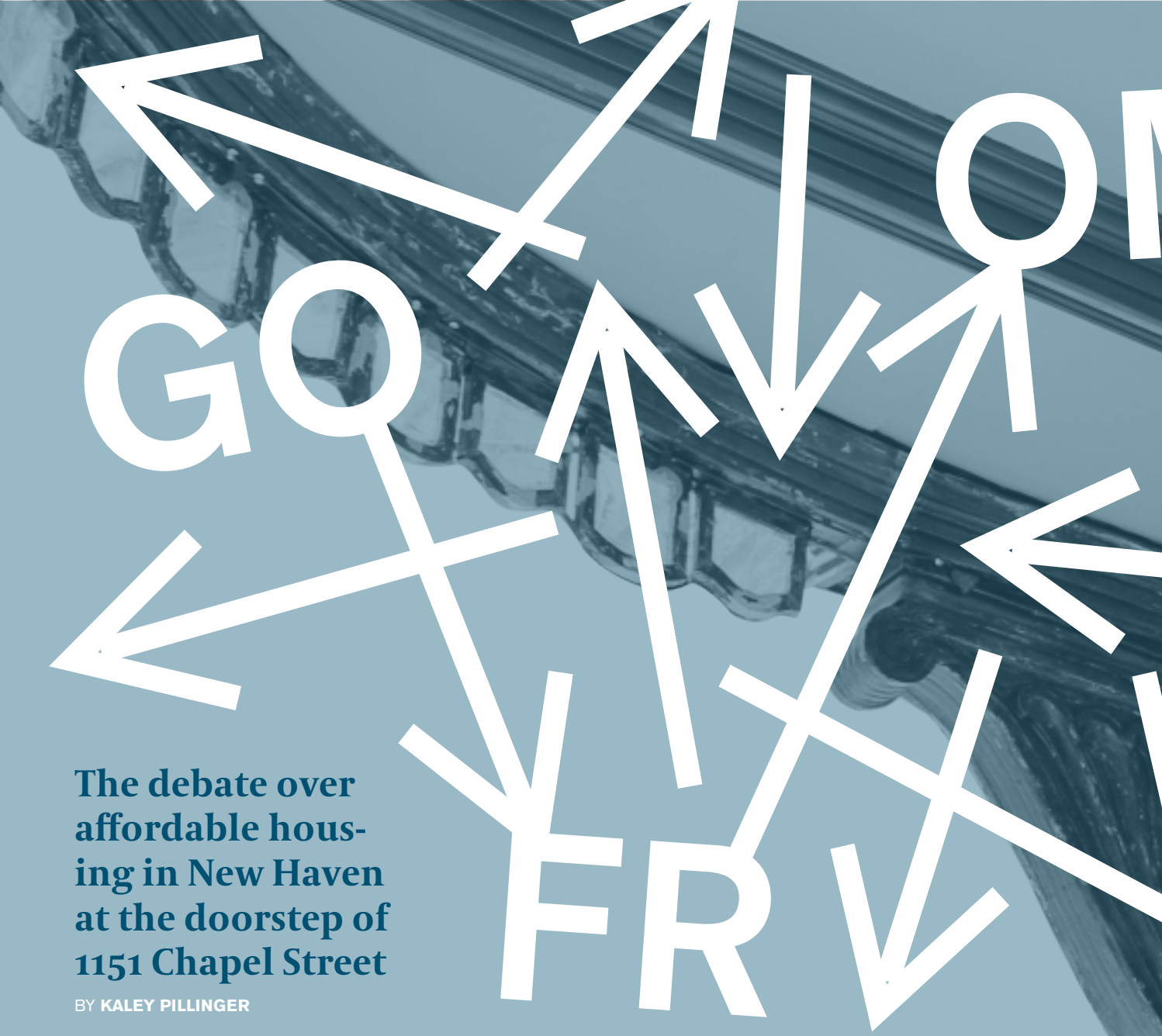
Lonsdale is heartened by performing artists' collective reaction to the crisis, but she knows that this collaboration is nothing new. "What we're seeing is something that is both the natural impulse of this community and something that this community has to do for itself all the time," she said. "Artists live economically marginalized existences anyway, so we have systems for mutual aid already set up."

Many artists are already used to rallying around one another for help, whether someone loses a gig or has a toothache but no dental insurance, she explained. "The pass-the-hat fundraiser at the bar, this is stuff that we all do all the time."

While these support networks have expanded from bars to fundraisers that span the continent, the communal culture that has spread across the United States in the wake of COVID-19 is for many actors just a part of their regular job.

"Artists are predisposed by their humanity to be in community with other people," Lonsdale said. "The very act of creating theater is an act of community building." Though these times are unprecedented, the sense of community is not.

Though these times are unprecedented, the sense of community is not.



The debate over affordable housing in New Haven at the doorstep of 1151 Chapel Street

BY **KALEY PILLINGER**

IT IS AROUND 3:00 P.M. when Johnny—or whoever else happens to be around and between shifts—sharpens the pencils. Somehow, regardless of the day or hour, each one is perfectly pointed, sitting in a bundle of similarly clean-erasered utensils in vases on each of the tables. They are all printed with the same text: "Poindexter Coffee: Graduate Hotels."

This precision in design is how Dominic Ruggieri, the general manager of New Haven's newest hotel, wants it. "I kind of love the fact that [students] see it as magic."

The Graduate brand—and the Yale brand to boot—is everywhere, from the sign on the front door proclaiming the hotel's inclusivity to the striped plastic cups students can use for water from a beehive-shaped jug.

To your left as you walk in is the Theo Epstein Scouting Room, a riff on the Chicago Cubs president and member of the class of '95, where all the books on the wall are blue and in various stages of fade. Among the miscellany, there is a Yale Class of 1935 airplane bag, a collection entitled *The Romances of Alexandre Dumas*, and a baseball glove so ancient it could have belonged to Epstein's grandfather. To your right is the Stirling Library, punnily named for the building's former owner.

In the Poindexter coffee shop in the back, the chairs are red velvet and the chandeliers sparkle. The far back room, once a ballroom and now christened the "Majestic Room," is still tiled in its original one inch thick sheet marble.

"Nostalgia is the word I like to use for it," Ruggieri explained.

Three o'clock is the time that Ruggieri can finally take a break from his desk and do a lap around the lobby. Then, he notices, is when the students begin to arrive in full force. But sometimes, when he stays around until the late hours, he sees a couple of Yalies "tucked in the corner at 11:00 at night, still sitting there studying."

Only one thing is off, and given



the precision of every other detail, we can only assume it is intentional. The lit marquee above the hotel's entrance at 1151 Chapel Street still proclaims in thin white lettering exactly what the building is no longer: "Hotel Duncan."

MIKE STERN IS THE ONE who brings up Murphy's Law—"anything that can go wrong will go wrong"—when I ask him about his latest photography gig. He was supposed to be photographing tuna casserole for a client, but the mushy food got disfigured in shipping. "I'm gonna kill Murphy," he says with an earnest laugh.

Stern—alternatively known as Mike, Mikey, and Stern Boy—is drinking Tropicana grapefruit juice out of a cup, the plastic bottle placed astride like a can of good beer. Although I offered him the seat by the wall, he quickly slid into the other one—the seat that doesn't face the Graduate, where he lived as a permanent resident, or "perm," in a cheap single room for 12 years.

He calls it the "Dysfunctional Arms Hotel."

Stern is tall, with a tuft of whitening hair; slim; and talks fast. He was born, raised, and college-educated in this city, even though his *Baw*ston twinge might indicate otherwise.

"When I was a kid," he begins his yarn, "a business associate of my father gave me a Polaroid camera." He started taking pictures. Of sports, of school events, for the yearbook. At New Haven College, now called the University of New Haven, he got his own 35mm camera. He followed his love of photography wherever it took him.

It led him to a job as a reporter at the New Haven Register. ("First of all, I couldn't type," and the long hours and boring city government meetings made him dread waking up.)

It led him to Beantown, perhaps where he picked up the accent, where he wrote copy for the Dunkin Donuts newsletter that went to franchises around the world. ("The marketing director calls you once a year for your

"The lit marquee above the hotel's entrance at 1151 Chapel Street still proclaims

review. He says, 'We like the work you do, but...you don't seem to wanna reach out for more work.' He says, 'For instance, would you [one day] like my job?' I said no.... Two weeks later I was laid off.")

It led him to work at an ad agency on the city's glitzy Newbury Street, where one day he went to supervise a shoot at a full-time photographer's studio. ("I was saying to myself, 'Gee, I like this!'... I came to him and I say, 'Are you looking for an assistant?'... He says, 'I'll put you on as a dark room guy because my dark room guy quit.'")

It led him to work for that photographer, who Stern learned later was a rude boss and went through employees at a rapid clip. (Nonetheless, the job only ended three years later because the boss "had an opportunity to go to New York to make the big bucks—as if he wasn't already making the big bucks—so I was back on the streets.")

To avoid going back to the corporate world, Stern decided to open his own photography business. At that point, he was in his early thirties, and it took a few years to get the business off the ground. He points out that it's not a cheap vocation. Between the cost of equipment, studio space, and his own lost time, "I ended up almost homeless. I starved for eight years."

He eventually made enough to live in an apartment at the top of Beacon Hill. "You can see the planes landing at Logan. It was gorgeous." He can still describe in great detail the exposed brick wall, the working fireplace, and the foot-wide cedar floorboards. "When you walked in you could hear 'em creak and give a little bit." The front closet walls smelled like fresh forest.

But the whole time, Stern was being broken down from the inside by his OCD, which he's suffered from since he was 12. "It's like being in a jail without bars," he explained. "You're physically free, but you're not mentally free."

He doesn't feel comfortable cooking, so he would eat out every night. Sometimes he would go to the fancy places like Jimmy's Harborside; Anthony's Pier 4; or Top of the Hub, which boasted views from the Prudential Center's 52-story height. He bought a red '59 Volvo, far out of his budget, that he maintains meticulously to this day. "Every dime that I made was pretty much spent," he shared. In other words, it was time to go home.

After stumbling through different places in New Haven (including one halfway house so dangerous, he recalls, "There was a knife at my throat, literally"), he moved into the Duncan—he didn't need a kitchen anyway—and started to catch up with his old friends. He made a deal with Stirling Shapiro, who managed the hotel, to pay $450 a month plus labor for a bedroom in the attic and a photography studio in the unused ballroom downstairs.

"You ever heard the saying 'You can't go home'?" he asks. "It's hard. It wasn't the same." It took him a couple of years to feel settled again. Yale helped. "There's no place like Yale... I'm enamored with... not necessarily the education but the architecture." One of Stern's biggest photography projects to date has been a photo book, *Yale's Hidden Treasures,* about the University's gargoyles.

I tell Stern I want to hear his stories from his time at the Duncan; I have all the time in the world to listen. He warns me: "You might need it." I tell him I'm ready for everything.

"Alright," he sighs. "Then it's not gonna be an article; it's gonna be an exposé. You got the good, the bad, and the ugly. Which one do you wanna hear first?"

ON SEPTEMBER 13, 2017, Stirling Shapiro, the third generation of his family to own and operate the building, sold New Haven's Hotel Duncan at 1151 Chapel Street to Chicago-based real estate firm AJ Capital.

The Duncan, built in 1894 and Shapiro family property since 1950, was starting to look its age. Plugging in a heating pad was cause for hazard, one family member explained, and a for-

mer resident reported that until almost the very end, the front desk was staffed by a man using a manual typewriter.

In the Duncan's 92 rooms, about half of the guests at any given time—usually somewhere between 39 and 45—were "perms," to use Stern's word, paying for rent in week-to-week installments of $200 or so, or based on special agreements with Shapiro.

The hotel in its place now, the Graduate, is one in a chain of themed boutique hotels in college towns across the country and, soon, in the U.K.. Each one is unique. The page for the Nashville, Tennessee outpost invites guests to "challenge [their] inner Opry star at our karaoke bar." The one for Tempe, Arizona advertises "southwest style with a desert nod"—every piece of furniture seems to be coral-striped, and sketches of state flora and fauna adorn the walls.

It seems to have found the right time to come to New Haven. Hacibey "Haci" Catalbasoglu '19, the former alder for the area, noted the hotel-building blitz around the city: "There is definitely a short supply of hotels, and there's a need that I think the Graduate is helping meet." The city, plagued by years of disinvestment and outmigration, by some accounts is experiencing a renaissance. The promise of new employers, driving the retention of younger and higher-consuming residents, is on the horizon.

It is also, Catalbasoglu acknowledged, a time of tension.

By different accounts, the city has been experiencing an affordable housing crisis since the crash of 2008. By DataHaven's 2019 numbers, New Haven's average renter is "$10,000 short of affording a 2-bedroom apartment." And although construction of shiny new apartment buildings is fast, the percentage of low-income residents is rising.

Of course, as went the Duncan, so went the perms. The several dozen low-income New Haveners living in the old building in single room occupancy units (SROs), a form of affordable housing already on the decline in the city, were forced to go from here. It was, by many accounts, the most visible and publicized case of residential displacement in the city's recent memory, even in a market rife with displacement due to absentee landlords and decreasing affordability. Indeed, the year before the Duncan was sold, 4.05 percent of renters were evicted, the 69th highest rate in the country, but most cases slipped and continue to slip under the radar.

"Before the Duncan [sale] and [the subsequent social movement], it wasn't the case that every single New Haven City official was talking about affordable housing," Ming-Yee Lin, a lawyer at the New Haven Legal Assistance Association (NHLAA), recalled. Today, it is one of the city's most significant political issues.

The Duncan tipped off a yearslong series of debates, advocacy groups, and proposals to fix the problem. To many advocates today, the fight has only just begun.

AJ Capital gutted the place—which by all accounts was long due for an upgrade—and opened its expansive glass doors to guests on October 3, 2019.

TO GET TO THE NEW HAVEN Board of Alders main chambers, you have to walk up the cast-iron main steps in the lobby. The steps themselves might fit in a 19th-century railroad station, and look ready to be lifted up into the ceiling like an attic drop-down. At the top, and if you make a left at the atrium, you'll find the chamber itself.

This room—with its rows of pews and labeled seats for each of the city's 30 alders—is where the Affordable Housing Task Force first convened on June 6, 2018. The task force, facilitated by then-Ward 8 Alder Aaron Greenbarg GSAS '19, was made up of a group of seven community and government leaders, including the nonprofit leader Ed Mattison and Karen DuBois-Walton, a member of the task force and President of Elm City Communities, the city's housing authority.

"In thin white lettering exactly what the building is no longer: 'Hotel Duncan.'"

DuBois-Walton widened her eyes when I asked why the task force formed when it did—instated in March 2018, a half a year after the Duncan announcement: It seemed so obvious. But even then, everyone was a little surprised by the Duncan's sudden importance. "Had that not happened as part of a larger context of pressures on the affordable housing market... I don't think the Duncan story would have been what it was," she explained.

Indeed, Mattison explained, before the Task Force, "There was a lot of moaning and groaning but not much happening."

The June gathering was to be the first of six meetings in City Hall, often in that same chamber, one each month until the Task Force legally disbanded in the new year. The large room was consistently full.

A coalition of affordable housing advocacy groups, self-titled Room for All, formed to take full advantage of the new platform. Because Room for All—which included individual community members and groups like NHLAA, where Ming-Yee Lin works; Mothers and Others for Justice; and Y2Y New Haven—was made up of locals who worked on these projects full-time and filled up the pews with their own members, these groups often ended up directing the conversation instead of the task force members up front.

But the time crunch was clear. Meetings could get "super super rushed because [the task force] was set to dissolve in [2020]," Ali Bauman '21, a Yale student who attended the meet-



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ings, explained. Mattison also shared that the Board of Alders—which was supposed to help staff the task force—was too busy to help much. As a result, avid Room for All members would put in extra work outside of the task force meetings to keep them as productive as possible.

The monthly conversations were sprawling and at times unwieldy, exploring issues of housing affordability from reducing parking lot requirements to the city's often-tense relationship with its surrounding suburbs to enabling the construction of tiny homes called accessory dwelling units. Most members assumed that the Duncan was a starting point and nothing more.

"I would say the one person that continued to carry the Duncan through the conversation was Ed Mattison," Bauman reflected.

In fact, when asked about SROs, Mattison jumped to say, "That's my thing!"

Mattison, who now sports a gray beard, first arrived at Yale Law School in 1964, straight from the Peace Corps in Colombia. He bought his first home soon after moving here full time, for only $33,000, in the area near Blue State Coffee on Orange. Today, the neighboring house, which looks just the same, went for $410,000 a few years ago. "Essentially all the kinds of people who lived on our block are gone," he lamented. In fact, "The lady across the street is the only remaining one."

After entering into semi-retirement, Mattison began working as the Coordinator of Special Projects at Continuum of Care, which, true to its name, provides a continuum of services for patients with persistent mental health issues, including substance abuse.

His "moment of fame," as he shared with *The Politic*, was back in the mid 2000s when he facilitated the sale of 360 State Street, a 32-story high rise for which construction began at the peak of the American real estate bubble in 2008. It had been an undeveloped parking lot for far too long, and "it wasn't even successful as a parking lot."

Mattisons's task was to broker a deal to sell the land to developers for $1. Not everyone was happy with what looked like a free lunch for the corporate types, and Mattison himself was disappointed when the promised set-aside of Section 8 units still ended up being unaffordable for many locals.

Today, the building has faded into the urban fabric. It is perhaps best known now for the Elm City Market on its ground floor.

360 State Street is one—very tall—piece of a larger trend. Mattison calls it the "Fake Renaissance." Cities like New York and Stamford are becoming increasingly expensive, and New Haven has become increasingly appealing following upscale development by local Joel Schiavone in the '80s and by Yale Vice President for New Haven and State Affairs Bruce Alexander in the '00s. Transit into the cities has only gotten easier and more popular for would-be commuters. One day, when Mattison was boarding the Metro-North from New Haven to Manhattan at 6:30 a.m., he was stunned that he "had the last seat."

With low unemployment, low interest rates, and increasing numbers of millenials moving into the city during the mid aughts, former Mayor John DeStefano explained with his characteristic good-natured frankness, there was "lots of excess capital and people started building shit all over the freaking place."

A big part of the problem, Mattison thinks, is that New Haven hasn't yet chosen its character. The people I talked to often commented that New Haven is not like Bridgeport, referred to synecdochally for high-poverty, high-crime Connecticut cities. But nor is it like Stamford, which from the Metro-North train looks like a series of shiny glass buildings, and is home to the corporate headquarters of the likes of vacation chain Starwood Hotels, kitchenware line Cuisinart, and salmon shorts-promoter Vineyard Vines.

As the opportunity for growth comes knocking, New Haven can dig in its heels and try to maintain its affordable, through preserving its often-dilapidated housing stock, or it can look to expand—at the peril of poorer residents. Or it can figure out a middle path. The door to the city's future has been flung wide open; it's unclear what comes next.

"The Duncan was the straw that broke the camel's back," Bauman said. The building's 30-to-40-some-odd residents made up a tiny part of the count of people experiencing housing insecurity in the city, but their dramatic displacement was key to mobilizing public support. The Duncan is now an inextricable chapter in New Haven's fair housing narrative.

HACI CATALBASOGLU wishes he had been a history major. "History repeats



itself," the former Ward 1 alder and Political Science major explained. New Haven, he thinks, is no exception. The leadership of the city—whether the local government, Yale administrators, or business officials—has been a glutton for redevelopment for much of the twentieth century.

The city was, after all, built on a foundation of experimental urban design. The Nine Square Plan, the famous 18th-century project that anchored the city around a central green and eight surrounding blocks, has become a key part of the city's legacy. That plan, the first of its kind in colonial America, has since become a historic landmark and remains a common touchstone for New Haveners.

When Richard C. Lee was sworn into office in 1954, however, he accelerated the pace of redevelopment. A report done by Lee's Community Improvement Program in 1965 retroactively laid out his claim to construction necessity: when he took office, "downtown was obsolete, congested, and physically and economically decayed." A report by the New Haven Journal-Courier in 1954 confirmed that New Haven was hemorrhaging retailers and citizens by the time the new mayor took office; Lee, in a statement to the Board of Alders, implored them to work to fix "a declining business district…too much slum housing and too little new housing."

Lee's plan was multifaceted and far-reaching, but is perhaps best remembered for the construction of the Oak Street Redistributor, a highway running through New Haven with the intention of promoting commuter access to—and spending in—the city.

But of course to make room, something had to go. The reported numbers vary, but according to the New Haven Redevelopment Agency records on file at Yale Manuscripts and Archives, somewhere between 650 and 881 families were displaced by the Oak Street Project. Approximately 350 businesses were forced to shutter or move. Some estimate that over 3,000 people were pushed out.

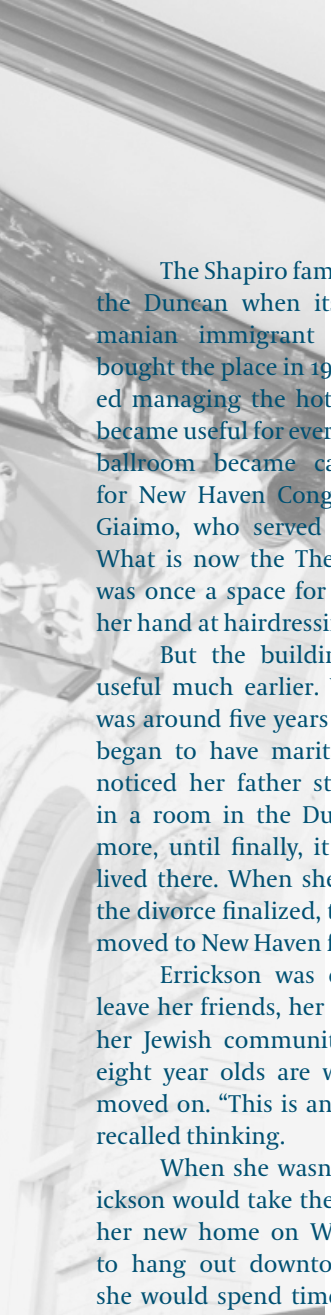
"The Oak Street neighborhood wasn't included in discussions of their entire neighborhood being plowed to the ground," Catalbasoglu explained.

New Haven earned its nickname "The Model City" under Lee's tenure, both due to the ample federal funding used in the project and its large-scale change.

Catalbasoglu didn't miss a beat before arguing: "A lot of the discussions we're having today were the same discussions that they were having in the '50s during the reign of Dick Lee."

AFTER THE TENTH GRADE, in 1970, Leah Errickson née Shapiro transferred to Richard C. Lee High School after several years too many of being bullied in school. Errickson was different from the kids there, she remembers. She had spent the first eight years of her life in the more affluent Woodbridge, CT. She wore fancy clothes. And, perhaps most tellingly, she described the school as "Named after Richard C. Lee, [who] was a friend of my dad's."

Errickson's father, Harold Shapiro, was a man about town. The once-Ward 21 chairman was known for his political career and business acumen—he also owned the Duncan Hotel.



The Shapiro family first acquired the Duncan when its patriarch, Romanian immigrant Irving Shapiro, bought the place in 1950. Harold started managing the hotel right away. It became useful for everything. The back ballroom became campaign offices for New Haven Congressman Robert Giaimo, who served from 1959-1981. What is now the Theo Epstein room was once a space for Errickson to try her hand at hairdressing.

But the building had become useful much earlier. When Errickson was around five years old, her parents began to have marital troubles. She noticed her father staying overnight in a room in the Duncan more and more, until finally, it seemed like he lived there. When she was eight, and the divorce finalized, the whole family moved to New Haven full time.

Errickson was disappointed to leave her friends, her nice school, and her Jewish community, but soon—as eight year olds are wont to do—she moved on. "This is an adventure," she recalled thinking.

When she wasn't in school, Errickson would take the long walk from her new home on Winthrop Avenue to hang out downtown. Sometimes, she would spend time with her older siblings and their friends. Other times, she would go alone: "I was kind of a loner [in that way]."

She would spend a large chunk of that time at the Duncan. As a child, she had the run of the place. The elevator operator and front desk clerk would let her into any empty room she wanted. She remembers with horror the Columbus Day parades, when she'd have to dress up all nice and sit on the Duncan's porch while her friends "snickered" from the sidewalk below. Sometimes, she would ask the operator to let her upstairs, so she could sit in her silly finery and watch from the bay windows of a suite without being seen.

Harold would also put the kids to work. Stirling or their middle sister Dorian would man the front desk; Errickson the hand-operated elevator. There would be campaign work too. "We grew up in a fishbowl," Errickson explained. The sisters would run voter coordination efforts for Congressman Giaimo, or Harold's latest connection, while Stirling drove people to the polls.

At age 15, Errickson moved into room 404 full time. Her mother had started fighting with her then-boyfriend in the Winthrop Avenue house, and Harold was quick to give Errickson—and her own boyfriend at the time—separate rooms in the hotel.

Errickson to this day seems proud of her independence. "I lived in a hotel going to high school," she said matter-of-factly. "How many kids did that? Noooone."

She ate at the Old Heidelberg bar downstairs, where meals were basically free, and schmoozed with adult residents. She kept her cats in the attic and had to put a pillow over her head to go feed them so the bats living there wouldn't flap at her. She cut her friends' hair in the ballroom in the back. (One time, in fact, she was both cutting hair and fending off bats that had entered the lobby.)

She graduated from high school in '72, opened her hair salon in the lobby in '77—the decor all gold and white and baby blue, and some of the furniture poached from the items of formerly-evicted tenants that Harold and then Stirling had hoarded in the attic and ballroom—and somewhere in between moved into room 512, where, she recalls with perhaps a tinge of urban lore, Rita Moreno once stayed.

In 1980, Errickson moved out and far across the country to Mesa, Arizona, where she still lives with her daughter and husband.

She shared that she never "really realiz[ed] just how crazy it was" growing up like that.

When Harold died in 1987, Leah, Stirling, and Dorian each took part ownership. Stirling managed the place full time, which gave him the upper hand in decision-making when it came time for sale.



DOWN IN THE BASEMENT was the Old Heidelberg, a staple starting in 1958. Stern still remembers it well.

It was a college joint, a comfortable mix of part-bar, part-bistro. Errickson recalls steak-for-two that could have filled four, something like a chicken Cordon Bleu, and "a huge shrimp cocktail." Stern opted for the steaks or the burgers, but mostly he was there for the company.

"Every Thursday night was college night, and we used to go in there when I was in college and try to meet girls," he shared. It was the place to be—for students, some nights; for Yale parents, others; for the Shapiro family, always.

When the original Old Heidelberg was run into the ground in the mid-2000s, it was replaced by the flagship restaurant of a Thai chain spreading across the state.

Under the management of Thai Taste, however, much of the space stayed the same. It had these memorable mahogany walls and wood beams. It was too expensive (or too much work) to get rid of the long bar on the left, which was ultimately used for storage. One local Yelp reviewer described it as an Old Heidelberg fan might have remembered the former restaurant: a "kind of a dark out of the way space." It felt old, "rustic," Stern recalled.

Although the food was often well reviewed, Stern, who had worked as a housekeeper at one point when staff was short, was skeeved. "Rats like this," he recalled, demonstrating by putting his hands farther apart than one would like to believe. "Water rats... Disgusting."

The "new Old Heidelberg" in the Graduate aims to harness the good while cleaning away the bad. The original tables and chairs had been preserved in the extensive basement behind Thai Taste, and all they needed was a fresh coat of shellac.

It certainly was a place to be. In the Yale Class of 1981 Facebook page, alumni prompted to think about the Old Heidelberg remembered the sign above the bar erroneously as "I.I.T.Y.W.T.M.W.Y.B.M.A.B.," and debated over individual letters. (The real sign, which reads "I.I.T.Y.W.I.M.W.Y.B.M.A.D."—"If I tell you what it means will you buy me a drink?"—took me and a few strangers several embarrassing minutes and too-good-to-be-true hints to figure it out before the bartender kindly told us. We, unfortunately for this story, did not buy him a drink.)

The nostalgia, as always, was the most exciting part. Ruggieri recalled that "Many times during the opening, we'd walk around [and] you'd hear somebody walk by and say 'Oh, they're opening the Old Heidelberg again?'... We wanted to preserve that."

There's still a ways to go. The cooking hood from Thai Taste remains unusable, and the restaurant's offerings are still barely more than bar fare. Ruggieri hopes one day to bring it back to its former glory.

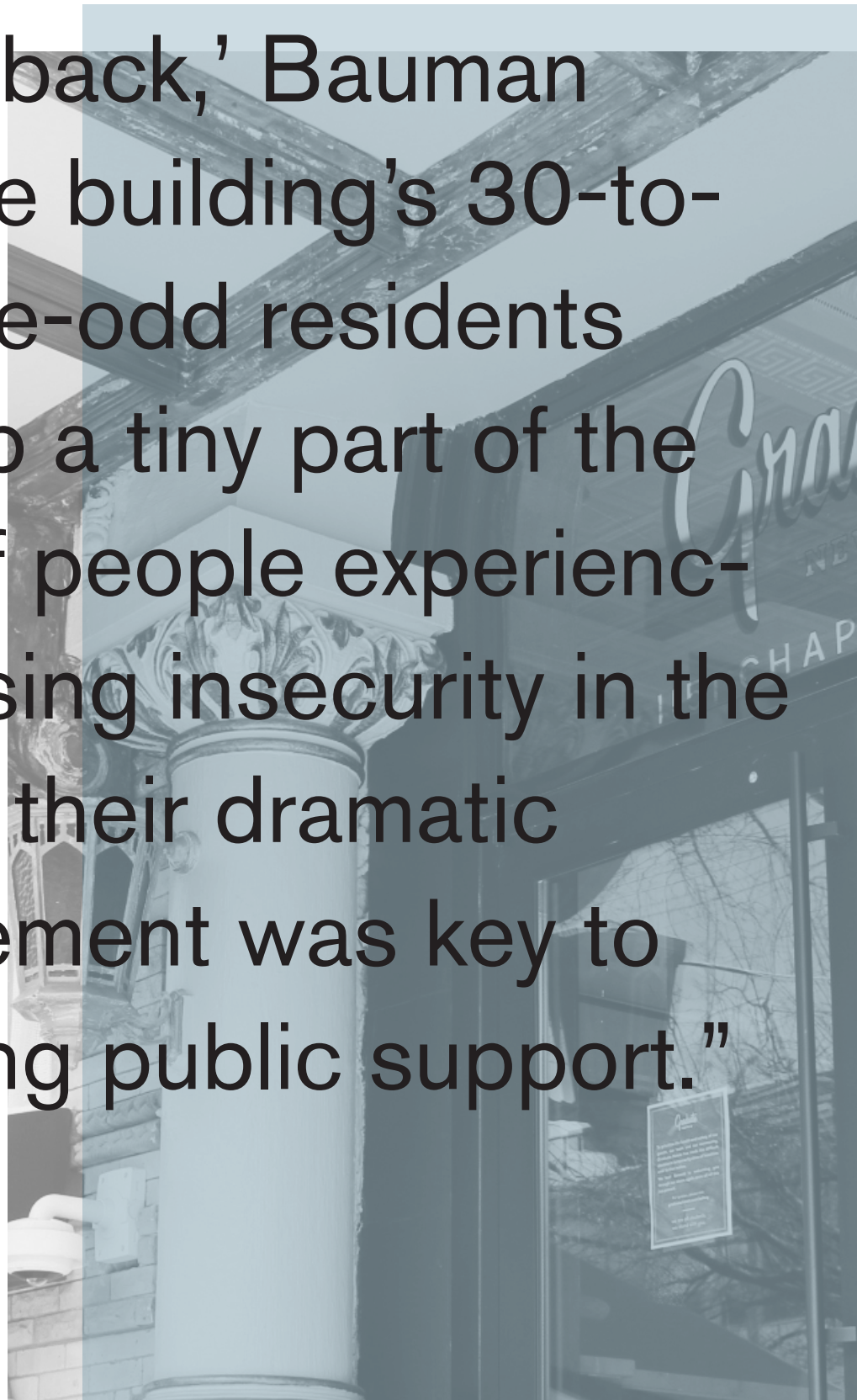
ERRICKSON TELLS ME she has been sick for 30 years. Most of the time, something hurts; some of the time, most things hurt. Nonetheless, between doctor's visits, supporting her adult daughter, and living her own life in Mesa, she always made it back to the Duncan to visit her favorite spots.

The first thing she made time for was pizza. She and Stern "used to go [to Yorkside] a lot." Before the bad news, they'd talk about everything and nothing, like no time had passed. Their health; the latest drama at the hotel. During his years at the Duncan, Stern ate a lot of frozen dinners that he would secretly microwave in his room. He would eat out, too, but going out with Errickson was a treat.

One time, the two were so deep into reminiscing that they decided to take a literal trip down memory lane.



“‘The Duncan was the straw that broke the camel’s back,’ Bauman said. The building’s 30-to-40-some-odd residents made up a tiny part of the count of people experiencing housing insecurity in the city, but their dramatic displacement was key to mobilizing public support.”





They slid into Stern's '59 Volvo and drove to Errickson's childhood home. "He could barely see. I thought I was going to have a heart attack," Errickson remembered without a hint of sarcasm. She kept pointing and saying "uh, red light!" But the car was too special for him to let anyone else drive.

They went to Woodbridge, past her old synagogue, and to the house she grew up in. She showed him her old school. Before they came back to New Haven, they stopped at a bar called the Blue Check, where her mother "used to take us and we'd get these big red fireballs. It burns your mouth out. Don't ask me why I liked it so much."

Long before the Duncan went on the market, the Blue Check, too, was for sale. As Stern and Errickson sat at the picnic tables in the back, the owner chatted them up. Preparing for the inevitable, they talked about their memories of the bar and what would come next.

The two of them drove back to the city.

Sometimes when they would have these Yorkside lunches, Stern would get swordfish sandwiches—"[Mike] turned me on to them," Errickson shared. "They're fantastic. [Only] seven dollars!" Sometimes, they would get pizza. The food was great, but what they really loved was the atmosphere. "You got all the old pictures of all the Yale people [on the walls], the old blues and everything," Stern recalled fondly.

"I love those people," he said. " I know all the waitresses and the waiters and everything." George, the owner, even put an advertisement for Stern's book on gargoyles in the pizzeria's front window.

WE START WITH the ugly.

"You ever hear of John Hinckley?" Stern asked conspiratorially. I nodded, vaguely recalling something from history class, or maybe a CNN documentary, about the Jodi Foster stalker and would-be Reagan assassin. "Where do you think he stayed when he stalked?"

That was before Stern moved in, but gossip in his day still spread like wildfire. He often heard it first: between working alternately as bellman, deskman, and housekeeper, and being a generally conversational guy, he got to know the guests. Stern remembered one who would come in from the Upper East Side twice a week to teach a course (Stern scoffs here) on "architectural shrubbery"; the man, he recalled, owned an island off the coast of Maine. He remembers Yale parents; fancy professors. He was always confused why those types came.

"If you want luxury, look elsewhere...and pay more," Bob Neubauer wrote in an October 2017 review of the Duncan. The Yelp page for the closed hotel is replete with the same criticisms, over and over. Rarely was anyone there to man the hand-operated elevator. The lighting was creepily dark. The hallways smelled like nicotine and sweat. Whoever was at the front desk was incompetent, or rude, or both.

A Yelper named Robyn summed it up in May 2012: "this place is a SH-T HOLE!!!!! However, we kind of enjoyed our stay here. (In a weird way!)"

That was only the beginning. True to his promise, Stern left nothing out of his description. He started off simple: "I gotta tell you: bugs, bed bugs,

roaches, mice and an occasional bat."

Theft was commonplace. Stern described "shrinkage," the process whereby the bellmen and housekeepers would slowly steal sheets, or laundry detergent, or toilet paper, or soap. One day, while she was still living there, Errickson was out at night teaching ballroom dancing at the Fred Astaire Dance Studio that used to be on Temple Street. She returned home to find that someone had broken into her room and stolen almost everything of value.

After she had already moved to Mesa, she came back to visit her hometown and stayed in the hotel. A guest had his expensive camera stolen. "I remember sitting with him for two hours in the lobby consoling him." She could empathize.

Stern likened the craziness to a Woody Allen film. Stirling's "hair was already gray," he said, "but if he knew... what happened in that place...it would fall out." If Stirling had known what was going on, Stern thinks, he would have sold the building long ago.

Neubauer, who edits a magazine and was visiting New Haven for a conference run by Yale Printing and Publishing, remembered: "I took a walk down the hall and it had a sort of empty and kind of spooky feel.... It seemed a bit like old New Haven."

When he had to return a year and a half later for another conference, Neubauer looked to rebook at the Duncan—it was cheap, and he didn't mind the adventure—but it was already closed. In his time between meetings, he walked up the main stairs under the awning and tried to peek in, nervous that the building was scheduled for demolition, but the windows were almost entirely covered up for construction. From what he could see, the inside was all building dust and disarray.

ERRICKSON BROKE THE news at Yorkside. It was the summer of 2016.

"She says, 'Stirling is selling,'" Stern recalls.

Mike: Jesus, Leah, couldn't you tell me when we weren't eating?

Leah: Well, a lot of times I don't see you when we're not eating.

"I asked Stirling how much time before I get thrown out," Stern remembered. "He hit the roof and didn't talk to me" for a while. As Stern recalls it, Stirling, who was known to hold an impressive grudge when he wanted to, also told other guests not to talk to him. He didn't want any of the permanent residents to get spooked. "I got along with [Stirling] great [otherwise,]" Stern added without pause. "It's just one of those things." Stirling did not respond to multiple requests for comment.

Eventually, though, everyone found out. In May of 2017, Jocelyne Barsczewski of the Glendower Group, the for-profit arm of Elm City Communities, held a meeting with the permanent Duncan residents in the lobby. That meeting kicked off months of individual consultations, house tours, and furniture moving. At that first meeting, Barsczewski reported, the Glendower Group was responsible for 39 permanent residents. (The New Haven Independent put the number at 45.)

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at thepolitic.org/go-from-here



AN EXECUTIVE ORDER IGNITES PROTEST OVER ARCHITECTURAL ERASURE

american **cornerstone**

BY **JULIA WU**

THOUSANDS OF NAMES are carved into the long black scar on the pristine green lawn; Maya Lin's Vietnam War Memorial evokes a granite river streaming towards the Washington Memorial. The dark earthbound representation of the devastation of war forms a stark contrast to the white tower stretching above the nation's capital city. Peering into the sea of names offers a still more haunting image: one's own reflection among the lost.

The memorial isn't just a wound in the landscape: it's a contusion amidst the surrounding classical constructions. The memorial slices through the collection of monolithic white buildings whose entrances are guarded by Greek Corinthian columns. Its sleek black granite marks an absence of classical design and a refusal to hearken back to what once was.

Further down the lawn stands the Vietnam War Memorial's four modernist companions: the in-progress Eisenhower Memorial, the National Gallery of Art, the Hirshhorn Museum, and the National Museum of African American History and Culture (NMAAHC). These five buildings are the only examples of modernist and postmodernist architecture along the National Mall, which is dominated by Neoclassical design.

With this context in mind, David Adjaye, the British-Ghanian architect who designed the NMAAHC, knew from the beginning that he wanted to make a building that did more than repeat classical designs: "[The NMAAHC] needed to speak a different language."

In an effort to break from the federal government's present-day echo chamber of classical architecture, he drew inspiration from various African artistic traditions: the facade's three tiers quote the shape of crowns in Yoruba art, and the intricate metalwork is reminiscent of that created by enslaved African Americans.

From the contents of the museum to its design, the NMAAHC had to overcome a number of hurdles. In 1929, Herbert Hoover first pushed to establish a federal building that honored African Americans; however, Congress repeatedly blocked the bill and failed to provide funding. It wasn't until 70 years later that Congress passed a bill to support the creation of the museum.

Even once construction began, it would take ten years for the project to be ultimately completed. Lonnie Bunch III, the museum's director, later revealed that the museum's team was also "curat[ing] exhibitions, publish[ing] books, craft[ing] the virtual museum" from the very beginning of the process in an attempt to demonstrate how thoroughly they considered every aspect. The building opened at last in 2016, unveiling a darker modernist design meant to remind visitors of the more painful sides of American history.

Architects like Lin and Adjaye consciously designed their nonclassical buildings to have specific—often disruptive—relationships with the landscape of the National Mall. Within the theater of the classical federal buildings, their designs are a performance of heavier, simplified lines.

However, projects like theirs are now at risk.

In February 2020, *Architectural Record* reported an executive order drafted by the Trump administration entitled "Making Federal Buildings Beautiful Again." It would eliminate modernist and postmodernist federal works under the pretense of "making Americans proud of our public buildings."

The leaked draft announced two major changes: first, the default style for all federal public buildings must be classical Greek or Roman; second, a Committee for the Re-Beautification of Federal Architecture would be established to determine whether existing buildings meet these requirements and what actions to take if they do not.

It appears that Trump has begun to finalize the plans in the draft, as he has already given Justin Shubow, current President of the National Civic Art Society, a seat on the Commission of Fine Arts (CFA). The CFA is a supposedly independent agency meant to advise the President on the design of federal buildings, while the National Civic Art Society is a nonprofit that has fervently railed against the "ugliness" of the modernist Eisenhower Memorial. Shubow's appointment is the White House's first step towards complete control over the aesthetics of federal buildings.

The executive order draft remains unyielding in its dismissal of non-Greco-Roman designs, which are

described as "aesthetic failures" and "widely considered uninspiring...or even just plain ugly." It claims that the American people favor a classical building style, but the study actually shows that Americans prefer Lin's memorial, the Chrysler Building, and the Empire State Building—all modernist constructions—to classical buildings like the Supreme Court.

Since its release, art critics, architects, and architectural organizations have harshly criticized the executive order. The American Institute of Architects expressed their "strong and unequivocal opposition" to the order's failure to "celebrate the differences that develop across space and time," arguing that it "represent[s] a regression" in the once style-neutral relationship between government and design.

The executive order proposal ignores that America's greatness was built on the backs of citizens from across the world, reducing the image of America to a white, Western one that only classical architecture can express. A policy that is justified through an architectural movement's claimed ugliness represents a nefarious projection of state power.

Almost every authoritarian ruler attempts to curate their country's aesthetic ideal, beginning with its architecture. Napoleon had himself painted in the throne of God from the Ghent Altarpiece; Hitler hired an architect to redesign all German buildings in a classical style. These dictators used control over art and architecture as a political tool to glorify themselves and to suppress dissenting expressions.

STATE CONTROL OVER ART AND ARCHITECTURE TRANSFORMS A SUBJECTIVE INTERPRETATION OF BEAUTY INTO AN OBJECTIVE EVALUATION OF NATIONAL IDENTITY.

Most revolutions are borne out of finding beauty in unexpected places. The hand-woven rugs during 19th-century industrialization spurred the Arts and Craft art of the era and factory workers' movements for greater rights. But state discretion over what constitutes beauty eliminates this possibility.

What is truly threatening about this executive order is its intention to develop a singular standard of beauty that represents the American identity. The executive order draft uses language describing classical buildings as "international symbols of democratic self-government" that "command respect by the public for their beauty and visually embody America's ideals."

The particular choice of associating classical architecture with American ideals of democracy closes the door on any image of America that is not predominantly white, Western, and stagnant. The draft's rejection of modernist combinations of non-Western symbols with classical design principles sends the message that only purely Western designs should be considered beautiful.

In recent years, white supremacist organizations have weaponized this idolization of classical architecture for their own ends. Identity Evropa, a white supremacist group targeting college campuses, carves the slogans "LET'S BECOME GREAT AGAIN" and "SERVE YOUR PEOPLE" onto posters of the Apollo Belvedere and David. The organization started with only 15 members, but quickly grew in number after Trump's 2016 win revitalized nationalist sentiments. They spread the posters around dozens of campuses

from California to Maine as a reminder of the alt-right's presence. By taking up space with symbols widely accepted as representations of Western glory, they believe that they can force their ideology into the mainstream.

These groups are continuing a historical trend: the Nazis used these same classical pieces as rallying points for their own "master race."

The government's unyielding prioritization of the cultural history of white Americans is troubling. Classical design was enshrined as part of this cultural identity when the Neoclassical Southern plantation mansions like Jefferson's Monticello were modeled after Greek and Roman buildings. The art and stories of white political leaders fill history books, and regulations like this new executive order draft continue to reinforce this "civilization tradition" in many other aspects of American life.

The proposed executive order eerily echoes the insidious white supremacist's exclusive appreciation of classical art. Why are the Pueblo adobe houses or the ranch-style farm houses of the Midwest not emblematic of our national identity? The decision of what architecture represents America is subject to the whim of those in power, who often make this choice to serve their own agendas.

The choice of classical Greek and Roman architecture as emblems of the "American Identity" also begs questions of whose voices are privileged in this executive order. What is the image of America we are building? Gregory Hood, a writer for the white supremacist online publication *American Renaissance*, applauded the executive order, characterizing it as "one small step toward reuniting white Americans with our civilizational tradition."

The policy favors assimilation and blind patriotism over critical artistic expressions. The emphasis on classical design elements silences any new dialogues between modernist architecture and classical tradition, and in turn, downplays the significance of this movement.

While the political arena has always presented itself as the playground of America's privileged class, the previous choices between styles of federal architecture offered designers the opportunity to create subversive governing spaces. For architects like Lin and Adjaye, Trump's executive order is especially dangerous; it significantly curtails the ability for artists to innovate new interactions between classical architecture's Western colonial legacy and larger cosmopolitan schema.

Complying with this model of classical uniformity risks destroying productive cultural discourse that is valuable in reshaping, or even disrupting, what we've come to understand as American history and identity.

For example, the layout of the

MEMORY IS JUST AS MUCH ABOUT FORGETTING AS REMEMBERING.

National Gallery of Art fosters a dialogue that stretches across heritages and time. The western portion of the gallery is a classical building, modeled after the Roman Pantheon, while the eastern portion is a modernist design by Chinese-American architect I.M. Pei.

REGARDLESS OF PROTESTS against the supposed ugliness of modernist designs, it is undeniable that the modernist movement was born from sentiments of innovation, progress, and growth. Modernist architects' manipulation of metal and glass developed over time, allowing them to use these materials in novel ways to show the post-war angst that gripped the world.

Modernist and postmodernist architecture is about moving forward, reappropriating classical elements until they become something new. Despite what the draft order suggests, classicism and modernism are not polar opposites; in fact, modernism grew out of classicism. It uses the same mathematical precision of the classical style, but reflects the reality that after the world wars, the rigid order of classical architecture no longer echoed the public's psyche. The modernists ruptured the traditional order by incorporating more globalized symbols. It is merely a sign of progress that Greek and Roman art can be made more beautiful with modernist innovations upon that tradition.

All art and architecture is inherently political because they are products of the social and political conditions under which they are created. Even the seemingly simple act of choosing to paint one landscape over another asks the artist to decide if one scene is more worthy of being painted. Neil Leach, a British architect and critical theorist, explains that architecture is made political by the "political associations a building may have" or how a building may facilitate "the practice of those politics through its physical forms."

Just as banks often hire architects to design buildings that represent stability, endurance, and reliability, the government determines how federal buildings' aesthetics represent the nation's values and identities. However, the current administration's desire to reinforce Western Europe's influence on American national identity reveals that this whiteness is nothing more than an elusive story for those stuck in the past to cling to.

It makes sense that authoritarian leaders would petition a return to the past. No matter how closely their columns resemble the Greeks', we can never call the buildings we create now classical—they will always be Neoclassical. The past is already gone. It holds power for reactionary authoritarian leaders exactly because it is irrecoverable. Memory is just as much about forgetting as remembering. The past's irrecoverability allows leaders to distort it under the guise of returning to what once was.

This decision has only revealed America's own insecurities. In a shroud of uncertainty, fear of the unknown, and wavering faith in Americans' ability to create innovative beauty, Trump has determined that we can only follow ancient trends to reinforce our superiority over our history. In embracing the infallibility of the past, we foreclose the possibility to create a new future.

A Conversation with Heather Edney

Bitter pills and small victories in combating the opioid crisis

BY **EUNICE PARK**

Heather Edney is the Director of Communications and Development at Homeless Health Care Los Angeles. One of Homeless Healthcare Los Angeles's key services is its Center for Harm Reduction in Downtown Los Angeles, a block from Skid Row, which distributes naloxone packets and provides opiate overdose resources for people who use drugs. Edney helped create the National Harm Reduction Coalition and was selected for the Obama administration's SAMHSA Opioid Overdose Prevention Working Group, the first federal program for overdose prevention.

THE POLITIC: HOW DID YOU BECOME INVOLVED WITH HARM REDUCTION AND SUBSTANCE USE TREATMENT ADVOCACY?

EDNEY: When I was a college student at University of California, Santa Cruz, I became involved with a partner who had HIV. [She] unfortunately passed away, and I started caring for her little kid who [also] got HIV.

In the early 90s, overdose prevention advocacy was very grassroots. Diabetics and nurses provided users with stolen, clean needles. I started hustling, writing grants, engaging with volunteers, and even designed a major in "Needle Exchange." I was in Santa Cruz for 13 years organizing needle exchange programs. By the time I left, we had developed two centers [each] with a two million dollar budget.

During [that] whole time, I was using drugs. I started when I was very young, and I was highly functional until the end of my usage. But I was miserable. So I'm very personally connected to this issue.

HOW HAVE YOU CHANGED YOUR ADVOCACY OVER TIME, ESPECIALLY GIVEN INCREASED MEDIA ATTENTION TO THE OPIOID CRISIS?

The media made the opioid crisis a crisis when it started killing white men. But it has always been killing people no one cared about–people of color, women, injection drug users.

This has been a bitter pill for me to swallow. We have already lost so many people. But there are finally federal resources. We've slowly begun to

The media made the opioid crisis a crisis when it started killing white men. But it has always been killing people no one cared about–people of color, women, injection drug users.

see addiction as a public health issue. It is critical to have treatment as an option for drug users when they want and need it.

AFTER ALL YOUR YEARS TACKLING THIS TREMENDOUS ISSUE, HOW DO YOU REMAIN PASSIONATE, YET NOT OVERLY EMOTIONALLY ATTACHED TO PEOPLE YOU'RE WORKING WITH? HOW DO YOU NOT GET JADED?

I am jaded. Not in the traditional sense, but in that I'm paying the price. I don't have my own kids, and I can't be in a relationship because I made a decision—and I really don't mean this in a martyrly, saintly way—but I made a decision to do this with my life and serve this community.

My best friends have also done this work for 20 years and feel the same way. It's finding joys in little things as a way to get through. For me, one of these joys was coming up with the idea for "Skid Rover," where we supply food, collars, and leashes for our clients' dogs. It really lights people up, and shows that we want to help with something important to them, their most precious companion. It's those small little victories.

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